way, Ibrahim was obviously representing a big, secular call for change. His party was being backed by the Americans, which should close the mouths of people who imagine WikiLeaks automatically takes up causes opposed to America. Like some of the Middle Eastern uprisings to come, this was a clean fight, and America was backing the right horse (without having groomed the favourite, which they did for years with Mubarak). Ibrahim was also likeable, having spent the six years he was locked up in prison reading Shakespeare. You can probably trust a man's sense of human nature if he has spent every day for that long studying Othello and Julius Caesar. We spent our time running ideas past the opposition reformers and writing some papers. It was dangerous work. One night, coming out of the headquarters and walking down a dark side-street, a place filled with shops and cafés, a man jumped out and flashed his card at me. At first, I thought he was a hawker. Turns out he was secret police. He asked me for ID, and I said I'd get it from the car, and on the way got a message to my friends from the opposition. I told him I was a journalist and wouldn't say anything more to him. The opposition guys were round in no time, pulling me away from the agent.

In the end the governing party held on to their seat in Bagan Pinang, but the mood among Malaysia's opposition was that this was just one minor battle, part of a long war that the Barisan Nasional were bound to lose. Our friends at *Malaysia Today* were certainly taking the long view rather than worrying about one by-election: 'Ever since the epic 12th general elections, which saw a realignment of the political landscape, the average Malaysian, normally apathetic to politics due to the boring regularity of BN's sweeping victories, has started to take an interest in elections, especially the next general election.'

We were doing so many kinds of work, and on so few resources, that I began to think of ways to steady the organisation and give it a home. A home is not an easy thing to contemplate when it comes to WikiLeaks: we have active servers operating at secret locations all over the world; we have a network of staff and contacts, most of them wishing to remain nameless, who are never to be found in the same place at the same time. WikiLeaks was different from any other kind of media organisation: we were never going to have a reception desk and a coffee machine, never mind a research department and annual holidays. People imagine I live out of a rucksack because I'm some kind of weirdo. Well, they're right, I am some kind of